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Sonoma State president quits over Israel

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Sonoma State University President Ming-Tung "Mike" Lee stepped down Friday, one day after California State University officials placed him on leave for unilaterally announcing that the campus would sever academic and financial ties with Israel.

Lee had negotiated with Students for Justice in Palestine to persuade them to remove tents they set up on Sonoma State's campus in Rohnert Park. The deal they reached included a promise to review the university's investments and seek "ethical alternatives" if needed -- but also an unprecedented academic boycott of Israel.

CSU Chancellor Mildred Garcia labeled Lee's action "insubordination" on Thursday and quickly named an acting president. On Friday, Garcia announced that Lee "has informed me of his decision to retire."

Lee had been in the president's role for less than two years, following a 28-year career as an administrator and business professor at Sacramento State. He came out of retirement in 2022 to take over at Sonoma State when former President Judy Sakaki resigned amid sexual harassment and retaliation allegations.

But after announcing an agreement Tuesday that was celebrated by pro-Palestinian student protesters because it singled out Israel -- and included a promise to elevate the activists to advisors who would hold administrators accountable for complying with the boycott of the Jewish state -- Lee encountered swift backlash from Jewish leaders, including state Sen. Scott Wiener, D-San Francisco.

"Yesterday the President of Sonoma State University aligned the campus with BDS (the boycott, divest and sanction) movement whose goal is the destruction of Israel, home to (7 million) Jews," Wiener posted Wednesday on social media.

He and Assembly Member Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino (Los Angeles County), co-chairs of the state Legislature's Jewish Caucus, thanked Garcia on Thursday for addressing the issue quickly, and said that the state-funded university's "endorsement of an academic boycott was totally unacceptable."

The accord struck by Lee's administration went beyond those reached with protesters at San Francisco State and Sacramento State, which focused not on any one nation, but on examining financial ties with companies or regions of the world that violate human rights.

"Our role as educators is to support and uplift all members of the California State University," Garcia said Thursday in her statement announcing the disciplinary action. "The heart and mission of the CSU is to create an inclusive and welcoming place for everyone we serve, not to marginalize one community over another."

Lee publicly apologized on Wednesday evening and said he acted without the approval of Garcia or other CSU leaders.

Both Lee's apology and his original announcement had been available on the Sonoma State website Thursday but were gone by Friday.

Garcia issued no update on the status of the agreement with the student protesters.

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